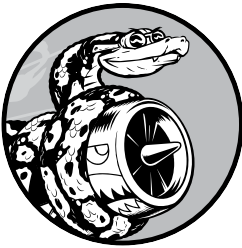


9

CLASSES



Object-oriented programming (OOP) is one of the most effective approaches to writing software. In object-oriented programming, you write *classes* that represent real-world things and situations, and you create *objects* based on these classes. When you write a class, you define the general behavior that a whole category of objects can have.

When you create individual objects from the class, each object is automatically equipped with the general behavior; you can then give each object whatever unique traits you desire. You'll be amazed how well real-world situations can be modeled with object-oriented programming.

Making an object from a class is called *instantiation*, and you work with *instances* of a class. In this chapter you'll write classes and create instances of those classes. You'll specify the kind of information that can be stored in instances, and you'll define actions that can be taken with these instances. You'll also write classes that extend the functionality of existing classes, so similar classes can share common functionality, and you can do more with